

Munasinghe-Fernando Travel Magazine

FRANCE

Lourdes • Paris

★ A PILGRIMAGE

 THE EIFFEL TOWER

 PARIS BOULANGERIES

INSIDE: **Lourdes** — the candlelight procession at the Sanctuary · **Eiffel Tower at 22:30** — booked and confirmed · **Sacré-Cœur** at dawn · **Louvre** with kids · **Sainte-Chapelle's** stained glass

Munasinghe-Fernando Family • Tue 28 Jul — Thu 30 Jul 2026

Welcome to two Frances.



Who we are — the Munasinghe-Fernando five, at golden hour outside the Sanctuary of Our Lady of Lourdes. Candle-shields in hand, an hour before the torch procession that opened our France.

France was a country of contrasts. The first was Lourdes — a small Pyrenean town that becomes, every summer, one of the world's largest Catholic pilgrimage sites. The second was Paris — the loudest, most photographed, most romantic city on earth.

But Lourdes was no accident. Before **Aviann** was born, we asked Our Lady of Lourdes for a daughter — and promised that if she came, we would give her the name Lourdes. She came. So before it was ever a holiday, this first leg was the keeping of that promise — a pilgrimage to the shrine our daughter is named for.

In Lourdes we did the Torch Procession at the Sanctuary, where thousands of pilgrims carry candles around the Esplanade as the night settles. In Paris we climbed the Eiffel Tower at 22:30 on a Wednesday, with the sparkle show happening below us at 22:00 and the city stretching to every horizon.

Two cities. Two completely different experiences of France. Both unforgettable.

— *The Munasinghe-Fernandos, 2026*

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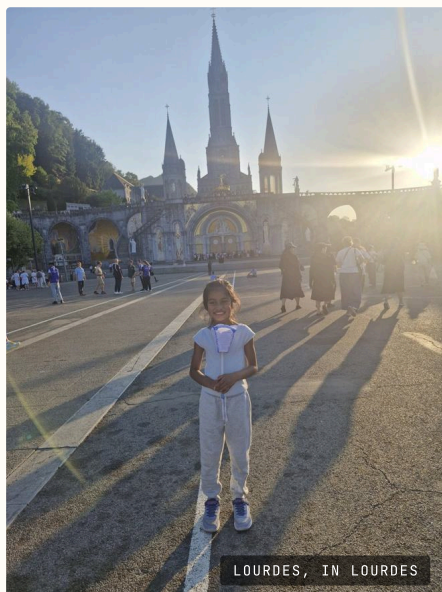
A candle, a song, a procession.

Every night from April to October, thousands of pilgrims march around the Sanctuary of Lourdes with candles and song. We joined them on a Tuesday night, all five of us, hands cupping flames against the dark.

TUE 28 JUL 2026 SANCTUARY OF OUR LADY OF LOURDES 90 MIN • 21:00 START



THE DRIVE IN



LOURDES, IN LOURDES



ALL FIVE • GOLDEN HOUR

The A64 south and the first sight of the Pyrenees • Avian — our promised Lourdes — on the Esplanade • and all five of us before the Basilica of the Immaculate Conception at golden hour, candles ready for the Torch Procession.

In 1858 a fourteen-year-old peasant girl named Bernadette Soubirous reported eighteen apparitions of the Virgin Mary in a small grotto by the Gave de Pau river. The Catholic Church investigated for four years and declared the visions authentic. Lourdes was transformed. Today the Sanctuary covers 51 hectares. Six million pilgrims come every year. They come for the Grotto, the spring water Bernadette dug up by hand, the underground Basilica of St Pius X (50,000 capacity), and the Torch Procession.

"I am the Immaculate Conception." — The lady's words to Bernadette, 25 March 1858. "

We arrived at 20:45 and bought candles for the children. The procession set off as dusk settled. Within ten minutes thousands of people were moving together around the Esplanade. The Ave Maria was sung in French, then Italian, then English, then Polish, then Spanish, then Portuguese, then Tagalog, then more languages we did not recognise. Avin held his candle in both hands the entire time — and each time the refrain came round, our four-year-old sang it out with everyone: *Ave, ave, ave Maria*.

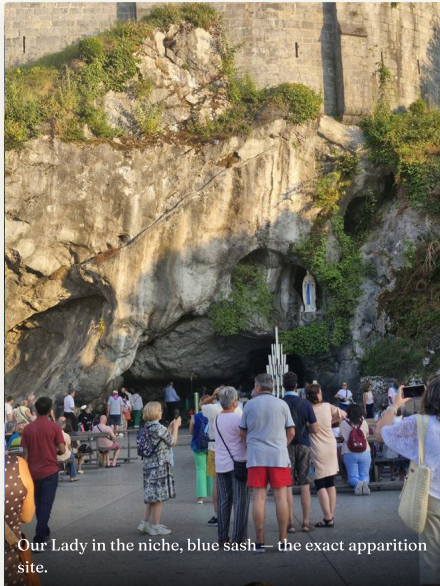
How a shy miller's daughter summoned the world

In February 1858 a fourteen-year-old miller's daughter, **Bernadette Soubirous**, went gathering firewood beside the river Gave and saw, in a rocky grotto at Massabielle, a lady in white who returned eighteen times. The apparitions — which the girl said named herself the Immaculate Conception — drew a scandalised town and a wary Church. Yet within four years Rome had recognised the visions, and the muddy spring Bernadette scratched from the ground made this modest Pyrenean market town second only to Paris in French hotel beds.

Today three to six million pilgrims arrive each year, many of them sick or dying, to drink or bathe in the spring water and join the candlelit Marian procession that flows through the sanctuary each evening. The Church stays strikingly cautious about the healings it is famous for: of thousands of reported cures, only around 70 have been formally declared miraculous after exhaustive medical scrutiny — and that restraint is the source of its authority.

At the Grotto of Massabielle.

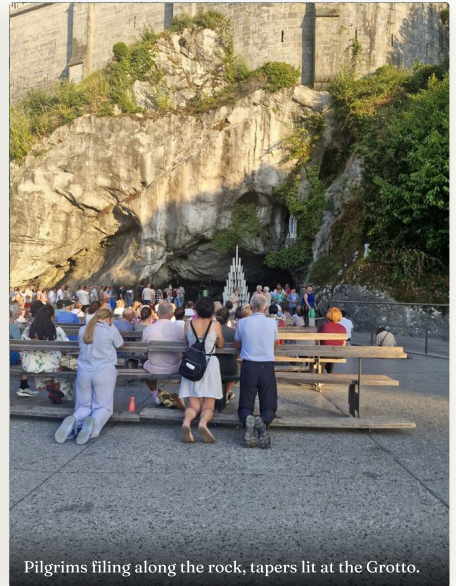
Where Bernadette Soubirous saw the lady in white in 1858. In the evening light we queued along the worn rock, touched the smooth stone, filled our bottles at the spring, and left flowers beneath the statue — then walked home through the little streets of Lourdes.



Our Lady in the niche, blue sash — the exact apparition site.



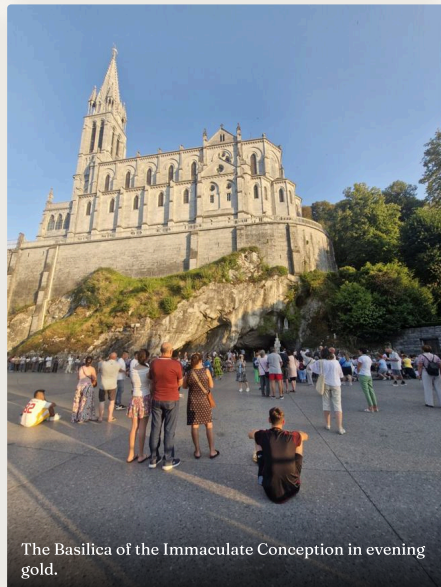
Flowers at the spring Bernadette dug from the ground by hand.



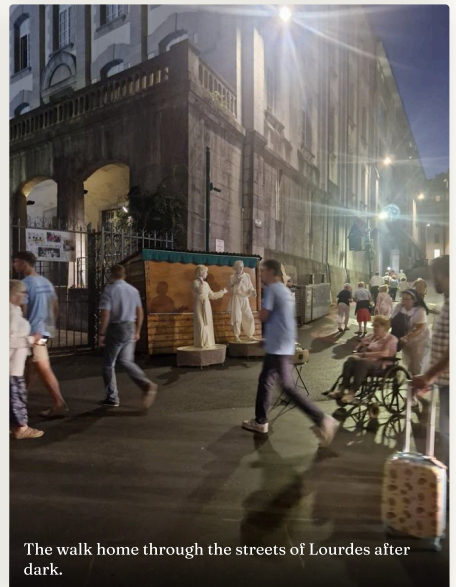
Pilgrims filing along the rock, tapers lit at the Grotto.



The Grotto beneath the spires, the crowd moving through.



The Basilica of the Immaculate Conception in evening gold.



The walk home through the streets of Lourdes after dark.

A candle, a song, a crowd.

As dusk fell we bought candles with paper shields, and joined the thousands who circle the Sanctuary every summer night. The Ave Maria rose in a dozen languages, the Basilica turned to gold, and three small flames stayed lit the whole way round.



Dusk over the Esplanade, the Basilica lighting up.



Three candles, three children — Avisha, Aviann & Avin.



The Rosary Basilica, and ten thousand flames below.



Avisha, her flame cupped against the evening.

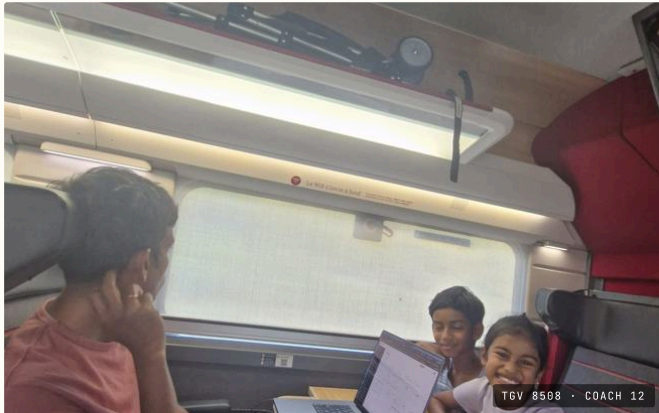


Aviann & Avin, candles lit, following the song.



The Ave Maria, set in the ground in every language.

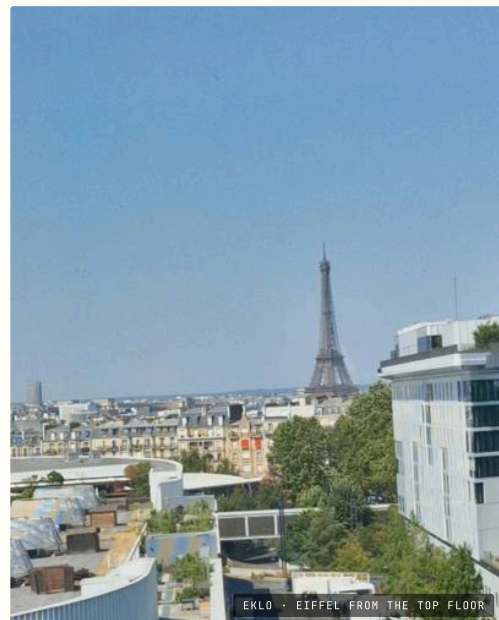
Toulouse to Paris in 4h 35m.



★ TGV 8508

4h 35min

We dropped the hire car at Toulouse airport, taxied across to Gare Matabiau, and rolled in a full hour early — just time for a McDonald's before boarding. Departed Matabiau 10:20, Coach 12, Seats 224-229; Paris Montparnasse by 14:55. 4h 35min, the journey itself a marvel of French engineering.



★ EKLO PARIS PORTE DE VERSAILLES

Family room

A family room for 6 with an Eiffel Tower view from the top floor. Métro 12 to the centre. Our base for the Paris leg.



The city that was rebuilt to be seen

The Paris of postcards — those endless honey-stone façades and radiating boulevards — is barely older than the camera. Between 1853 and 1870 Napoleon III unleashed Baron **Georges-Eugène Haussmann** on the medieval city, driving wide, straight avenues through a warren of crooked lanes and imposing uniform heights, grand vistas, parks and sewers. It was as much social engineering as beautification — yet it gave the capital the theatrical coherence we now read as timeless.

Its most beloved landmark was meant to be temporary. Gustave Eiffel's iron tower rose for the 1889 World's Fair marking the Revolution's centenary, and a chorus of writers denounced it as a monstrous, useless skeleton. Scheduled for demolition after twenty years, it was saved by its usefulness as a radio antenna. The older nickname — the "City of Light" — nods both to Paris's early street lighting and to its glow as the capital of Enlightenment thought.

Our first Paris afternoon was the **Louvre** — an old royal palace turned “universal museum,” some 35,000 works across eight departments. We queued for the Mona Lisa, then let the children lead us through the **Denon wing**. They came away with two questions — and each answer turned out to be a small window into how the old world thought. Here is the first.

Why is the cross forked?

A small mystery from the Denon wing — one of the kids spotted it first.



Among the paintings we passed, one *Christ Carrying the Cross* stopped us. Christ's cross is not the neat, carpentered cross of most pictures — it is a rough, **Y-shaped tree-trunk**.

It's deliberate. Painters called this a **crux furcata** — a "forked cross," or in German a *Gabelkreuz* — a form that was popular in 14th–16th-century German and Netherlandish religious art.

The fork carries the meaning. The cross is shown as a **living, branching tree**, casting it as the **Tree of Life** — the "new tree" that undoes the Fall in Eden. The raw, unhewn timber also nods to realism: the condemned hauling an unfinished beam to the hill.

So the strange shape isn't a mistake — it's a whole theology, hidden in the wood. (A Northern-European Passion panel of around 1500; the Louvre wall label carries the full attribution.)

Why is Egypt in the Louvre?

The second question — this one from the Egyptian halls: why is a Paris palace full of sphinxes and mummies?

It starts with **Napoleon**. In 1798 he invaded Egypt and, unusually, brought some 150 scholars, artists and scientists along with the army. They measured and drew everything, publishing the vast *Description de l'Égypte* — and set off a wave of "Egyptomania" across France.

Then a Frenchman cracked the code. **Jean-François Champollion** deciphered hieroglyphics in 1822, using the Rosetta Stone found during Napoleon's campaign.

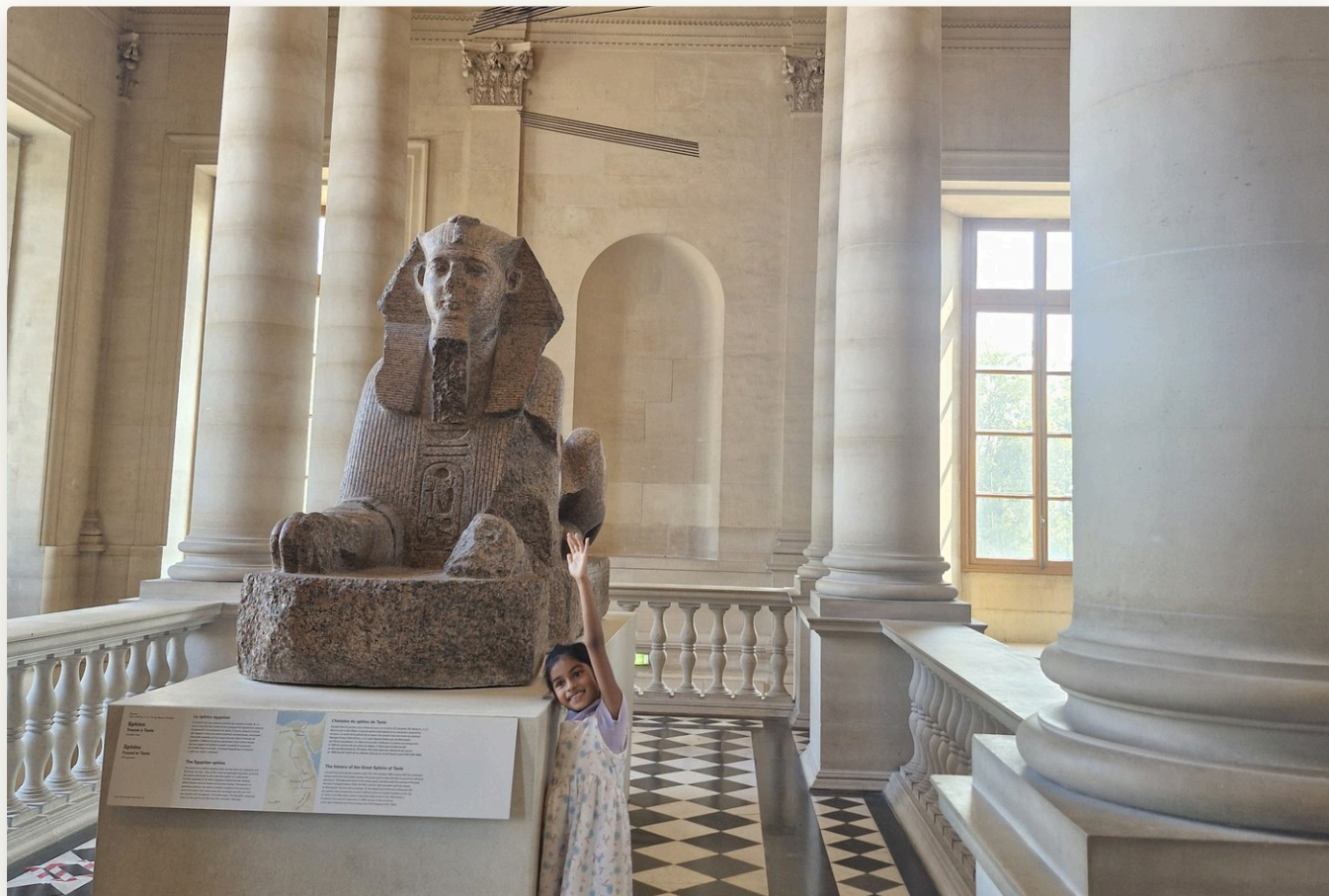
He all but invented Egyptology — and in 1826 the king made him the first curator of a brand-new Egyptian department at the Louvre, which he founded and filled.

The objects came by purchase (the Salt and Drovetti collections), by excavation, and through the antiquities trade of the day. And the deeper reason is the Louvre's very idea: a "**universal museum**" — like the British Museum — built to hold the art of every civilisation. Egypt is one of its eight departments.

★ THE STARS TO FIND

- 🦁 The **Great Sphinx of Tanis** — you can walk right up to it
- 🖋️ The **Seated Scribe** — 4,500-year-old painted eyes
- 👤 The **mummies & painted sarcophagi**

A footnote worth keeping: much of this was collected in the colonial era, and there are real, ongoing debates about how such antiquities were acquired — and whether some should one day return to Egypt.



*The **Great Sphinx of Tanis** — one block of pink granite standing guard at the threshold of the Egyptian galleries. Just as the wall label promised, you really can walk straight up to it — so one of ours did.*

Kings, coffins & cats.

The Louvre's Egypt runs wing after wing — colossal pharaohs, painted coffins, hieroglyphs by the acre. We walked the children up to a handful of the stars ... and came away with one more question, about cats.



A colossal royal head, cut from a single block of granite.



A pharaoh in stone, towering over the hall — and over us.



Painted coffins — each lid a map for the journey to the afterlife.



A stela: a stone page of hieroglyphs beneath a winged sun.



A Fayum portrait — a real Roman-era face, painted in wax over the mummy.



One of ours, dwarfed by a three-thousand-year-old coffin.



SEKHMET • THE LIONESS GODDESS

Why did Egypt love cats? 🐱

Egypt's cats began as pest-control — killing the rats, mice and cobras that threatened the grain and the family — and ended up as gods. The gentle house-cat became **Bastet**, goddess of home, women and children; her fierce big sister, the lioness **Sekhmet** — these four, carved in black granite — was goddess of war and healing. Cats grew so sacred that harming one could cost a life: the Greek historian Herodotus wrote that when a house-cat died, the whole family shaved their eyebrows in mourning. Hundreds of thousands were mummified as offerings — a civilisation that turned its granary guards into household gods.



PARIS · DAY 21

Straight up. Flat on our backs at the foot of the tower, the five of us made a ring of faces around 10,000 tonnes of iron — the lattice soaring straight up into the night above us.

The tower at midnight.

22:00 sparkle show from Trocadéro. 22:30 summit by lift. 5 tickets, 2nd floor by lift. Paris from 276 metres up.

WED 29 JUL 2026 CHAMP DE MARS + TROCADÉRO 2 HRS • SPARKLE + LIFT UP



All of us at the foot of the tower as it lit up gold for the night — minutes before our 22:30 lift to the summit. The 22:00 sparkle across the river had just finished: 20,000 lights, five minutes.

You should not climb the Eiffel Tower at noon. The queues are 90 minutes and the city below is white-hot and hazy.

You should climb it at 22:30. That is what we did. We watched the 22:00 sparkle from across the river at Trocadéro — 20,000 lights flashing for five minutes — and then walked down to the base and rode the lift up. The city was cool. The crowd was thin. The view stretched from Sacré-Cœur in the north to Notre-Dame in the centre to the gold dome of Les Invalides directly below us.

"Paris is always a good idea. — Audrey Hepburn"

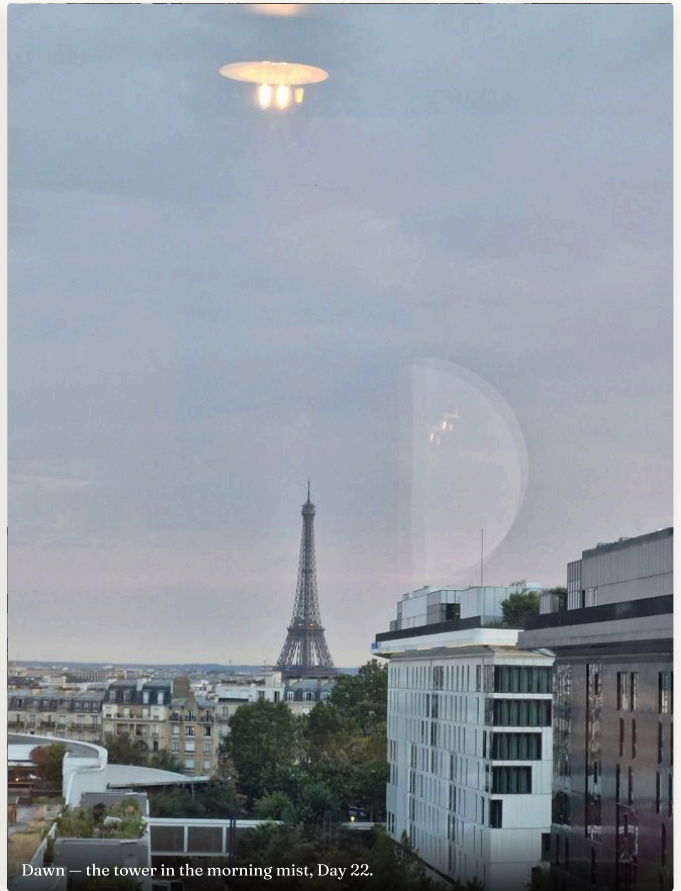
Avin was four years old, awake at 23:00, watching Paris from the second floor of the Eiffel Tower. We will hold this memory carefully. The tickets were €65 for all five (2 adults €23.50 + 3 children €6.00). The lift went up smoothly — though Avin, wide-eyed and gripping the rail, decided it was a roller-coaster and held on tight the whole way up. The wind on the platform was cold even in July. The kids leaned over the rail and pointed at the lights — "That one's the Louvre!" "That one's Sacré-Cœur!" — and we let them stay up there as long as they wanted.

Dusk to dawn.

Our top-floor room at Eklo looked straight down the city at the Eiffel Tower. We watched it sparkle at midnight, its beacon sweeping the dark — and found it again at first light, wrapped in morning mist.



Midnight — the beacon sweeping the sky from our window.



Dawn — the tower in the morning mist, Day 22.

Six things *we ate* and won't forget.

From morning coffee to evening pastries — the flavours of both our Paris days, gathered onto one page.



01 Steak-frites

Steak seared medium, a tangle of golden frites, a basket of baguette and a crisp green salad — the classic Paris bistro lunch, the whole table digging in at once.

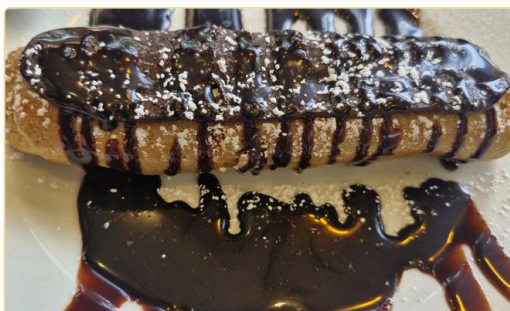
📍 PARIS BISTRO • DAY 21



02 Charcuterie & Fromage

A board of cured meats — jambon, saucisson — with brie and blue cheese, cornichons and a pot of fig jam. The French apéro on a plank.

📍 CAFÉ DE LA COMÉDIE • DAY 21



03 Crêpe au Chocolat

A rolled crêpe under a river of dark chocolate sauce and a dusting of icing sugar. The kids' pick, every time.

📍 PARIS CAFÉ • DAY 22



04 Macarons

Almond-meringue shells with ganache fillings — raspberry, pistachio, caramel, chocolate — around a swirl of vanilla chantilly.

📍 PARIS CAFÉ • DAY 22



05 Soupe à l'Oignon

French onion soup — caramelised onions, beef broth, melted cheese gratinéed over a toasted crouton. The bowl ends with the cheese stuck to the spoon.

📍 CAFÉ DE LA COMÉDIE • DAY 21



06 Moelleux au Chocolat

Warm chocolate cake with a molten centre, a scoop of vanilla ice cream melting alongside. The French answer to dessert.

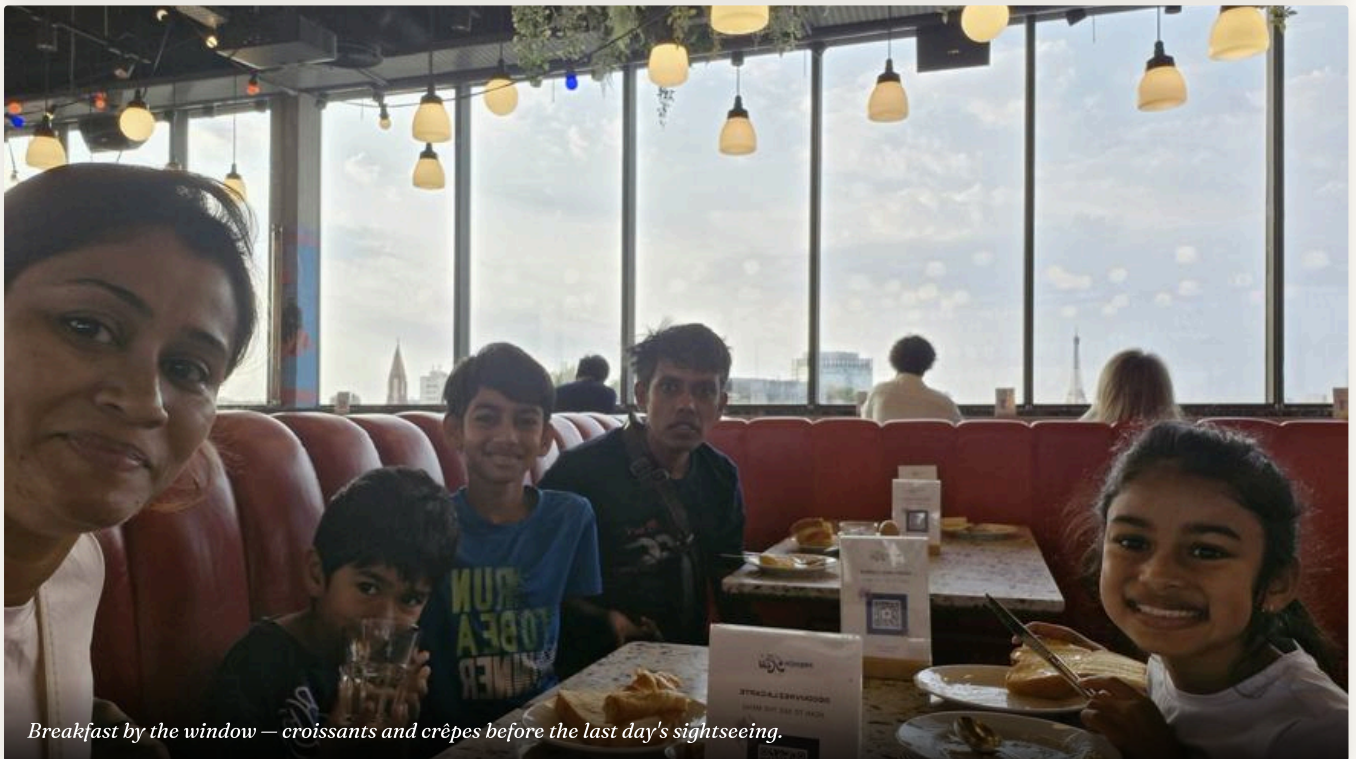
📍 PARIS CAFÉ • DAY 22

Five at the table.

Between the monuments, the best bits — a family of five around a Paris table, morning and night.



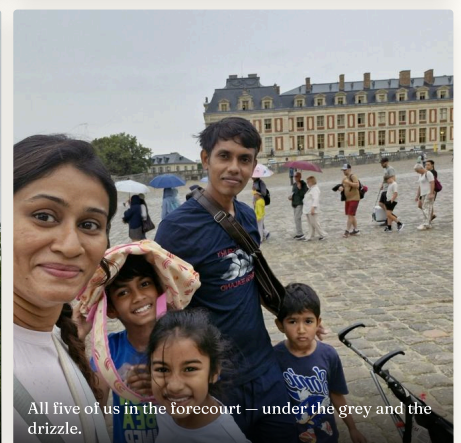
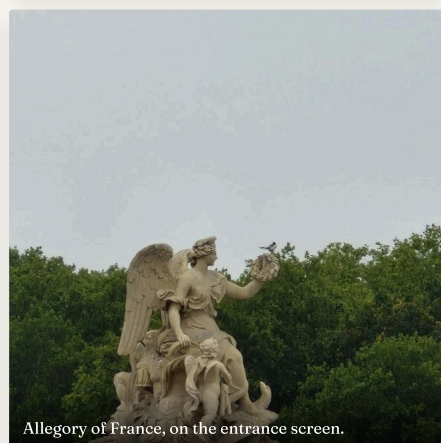
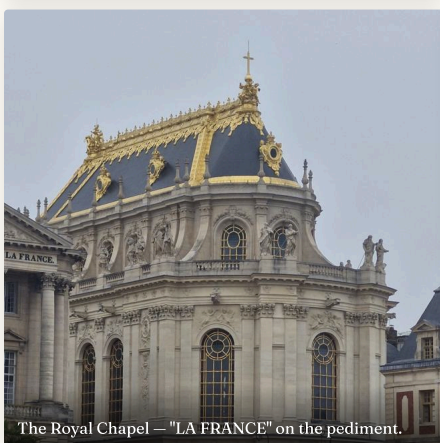
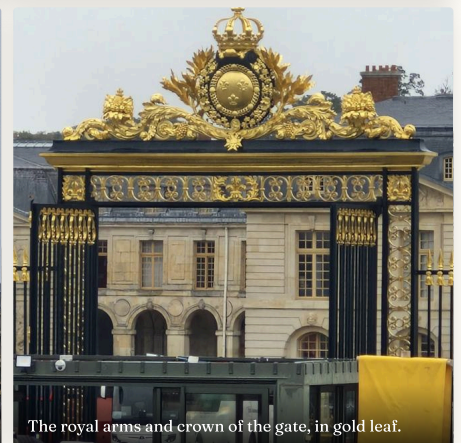
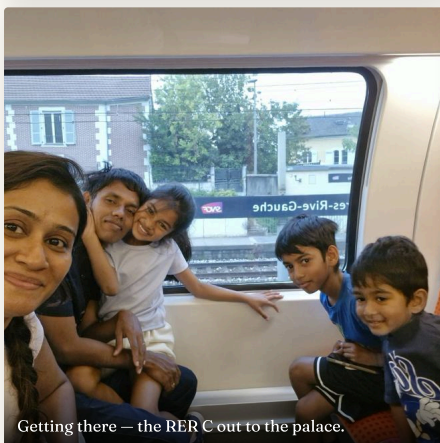
Dinner at Café de la Comédie — mirrors, gold lamps, onion soup and charcuterie (and, of course, pasta).



Breakfast by the window — croissants and crêpes before the last day's sightseeing.

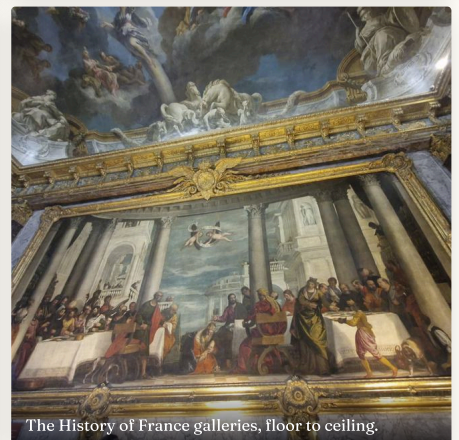
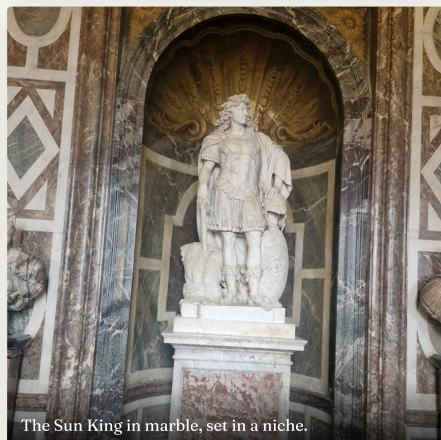
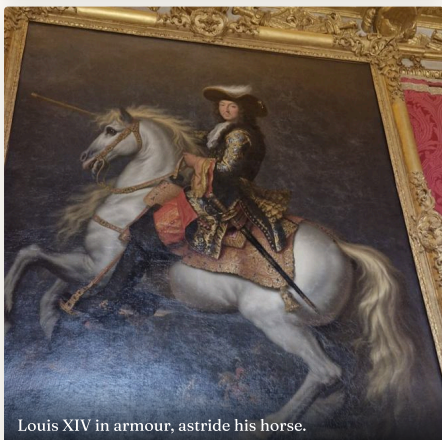
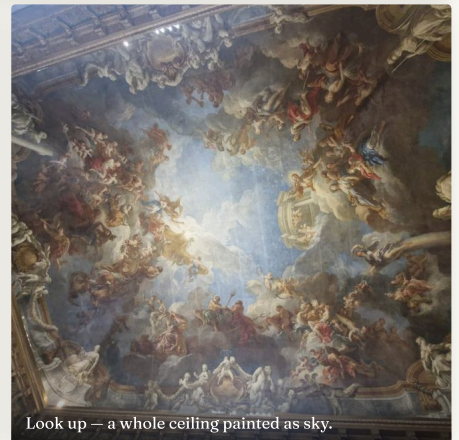
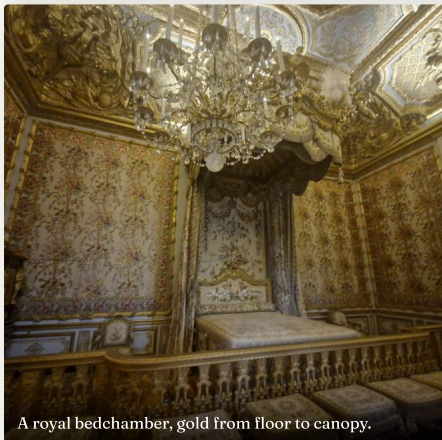
The Sun King's palace.

We nearly missed our slot and ended up in the long queue under grey skies — but the Château de Versailles still stops you dead at the gates. Louis XIV built it as the seat of absolute power: 2,300 rooms, gardens to the horizon, and gold on almost everything.



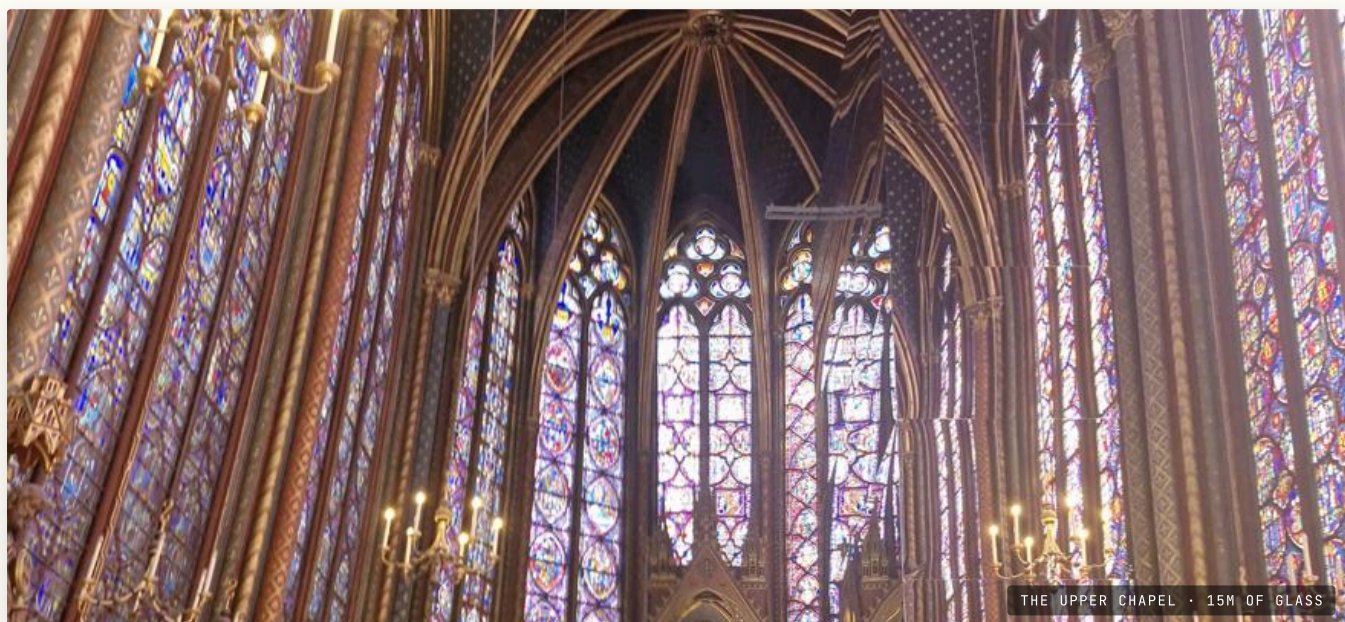
Inside the palace.

Past the queue and the gilded gate, the palace opens into room after room of the State Apartments — marble and gold, ceilings painted with gods and kings. At its heart runs the **Hall of Mirrors**: 357 mirrors facing 17 windows down a 73-metre gallery, where the court once gathered and, in 1919, the Treaty of Versailles was signed.



A box of stained-glass light.

*Saint Louis (Louis IX) built this royal chapel in just seven years — finished 1248 — to house Christ's Crown of Thorns. Its fifteen windows rise 15 metres, holding **1,113 scenes** of 13th-century glass, two-thirds of it original. On a sunny afternoon the whole upper chapel turns to jewelled light.*



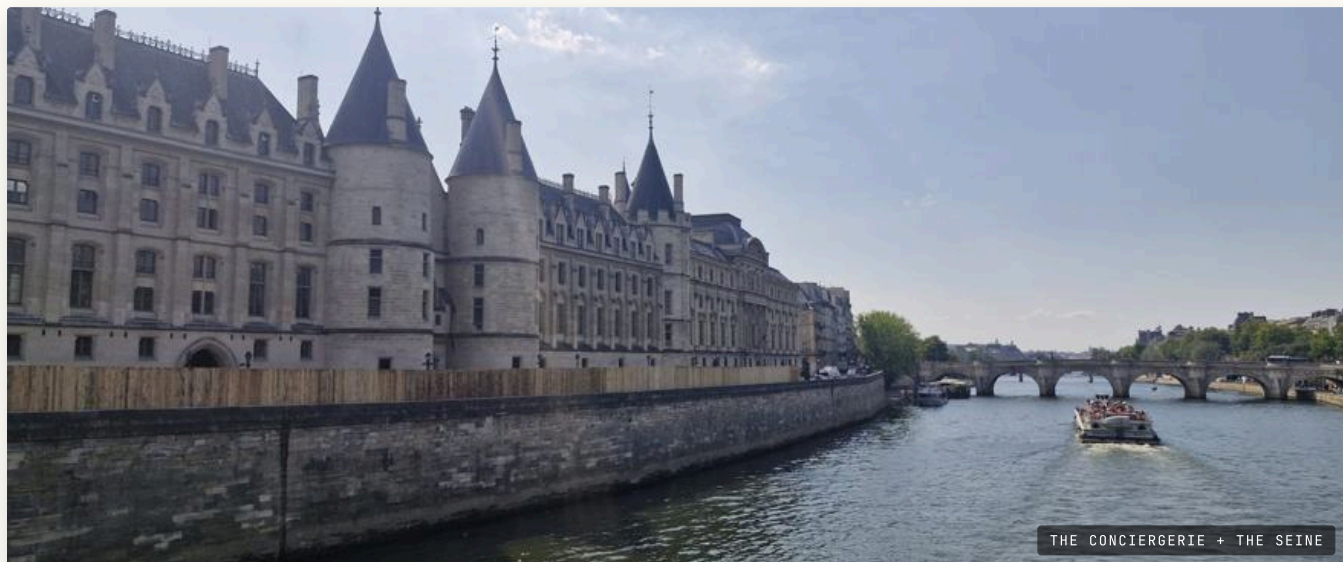
All five of us out front — the sun finally out over the Gothic spire.



Inside, with the windows blazing behind us.

Along the Seine.

*Sainte-Chapelle sits on the **Île de la Cité** — the little island in the river where Paris began two thousand years ago. Next to it stands the **Conciergerie**, a medieval royal palace turned revolutionary prison: Marie-Antoinette spent her last weeks in a cell here before the guillotine.*



We crossed to the island in the afternoon sun. A *bateau-mouche* slid under the arches of the **Pont Neuf** — the "New Bridge," which is in fact the oldest in Paris — while the fairytale towers of the Conciergerie kept watch over the water.

Two thousand years of the city, all on one small island: a Roman settlement, a royal palace, a prison of the Revolution, and the glittering chapel of a saint-king — a few steps apart.

A candle in Lourdes, a lift up the Eiffel, two ends of France.



France is two countries layered on the same map. The southern pilgrim France of Lourdes — quiet, devout, intimate. The northern capital France of Paris — loud, electric, monumental. We did the long route between them on a TGV, eating a baguette in Coach 12.

The Eiffel Tower at midnight is something we will tell the children about for the rest of their lives. We held them up to the railing. They pointed out the lights of the city. Then we rode the lift back down at 23:30 and Métro'd home, three sleepy children leaning against us.

FAVOURITE MOMENT

Avin's face on the Eiffel's second floor at 22:50. He could see the whole city below him.

HARDEST MOMENT

The long Versailles queue under grey skies — we were soaked in the drizzle before we even reached the gates.

IF WE COME BACK...

A week in Paris. The Loire châteaux. Brittany. Provence in lavender season.

— Avinesh, Lana, Avisha, Aviann & Avin Munasinghe-Fernando
Lourdes → Toulouse → Paris • 28–30 July 2026

★ NEXT ISSUE ★

NETHERLANDS

Amsterdam canals, Anne Frank's diary, and a cousin's house to come home to.